



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Columbus Classical Academy
School Website: <https://columbusclassical.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Columbus Classical Academy (CCA) demonstrates strong, explicit alignment with classical education principles across the key Rubric categories. The publicly visible materials portray a school anchored in virtue, truth, goodness, and beauty, with a curricular and pedagogical program that centers on the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books and primary-source engagement, and a mix of Socratic seminar and dialogue-based pedagogy in the upper grades. The school presents itself as Hillsdale College Curriculum School and, in some materials, emphasizes a biblical-Christian foundation while maintaining a civic, non-proselytizing stance in formal curriculum. Taken together, the evidence suggests a CLASSICAL orientation with robust fidelity to foundational elements such as formation of character, integration of liberal arts, and a coherent classical pedagogy, paired with community and parental engagement. The analysis below triangulates public materials from CCA's site with the classical education rubric drawn from the knowledge-base lexicon.

Key signals from the knowledge sources indicate:

- Religious and metaphysical foundations: explicit biblical-Christian framing appears in sanctuary-like statements about a biblical foundation and Apostles' Creed alignment in some materials, with a Christ-centered moral horizon, while avoiding catechesis in the curriculum per stated policy. This supports a strong religious/metaphysical baseline.
- Purpose and goals: the school foregrounds virtue formation, character formation, and a mission to cultivate truth, goodness, and beauty, not merely job-readiness; there are explicit statements about forming minds for virtue and civic life.
- Curriculum: clear articulation of grammar/logic/rhetoric (Trivium) and a curriculum scaffold connected to Great Books/primary sources, Latin, history, and integrated study across subjects. The Hillsdale curriculum framing is repeatedly cited.
- Pedagogy: a blend of contemplative/restful moments and rigorous Socratic-style engagement in upper grades, with lower-school singing/chanting/memory-building, and upper-school seminars/debates.
- Faculty: emphasis on teachers as mentors, the living curriculum, and a culture of virtue and care; faculty are described as intentional, virtuous models, and as core to the school's ethos.
- Parents & Community: explicit partnership with families, parent engagement through information packets, parent-education opportunities, and open campus/involvement; a shared mission with families is repeatedly highlighted.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Public materials acknowledge a biblical foundation and Apostles' Creed alignment, signaling a theology-infused basis for formation, while maintaining a public-school-friendly stance on non-proselytizing curriculum. The site explicitly states a biblical foundation and Christian roots in some materials, including statements about a biblical foundation underpinning the classical education, and references to a biblical

framework in governance and mission. - The Hillsdale affiliation is clearly stated, anchoring the program in a long-standing classical framework that emphasizes truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable. - Some pages emphasize a covenantal or biblically informed moral horizon (e.g., “biblical foundation” and related language) while not requiring a faith declaration for enrollment.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, character, faith, biblical, creed, moral formation, sacred, Logos, transcendental, contemplation, virtue ethics, great conversation, formation. Examples drawn from the site’s framing of virtue and biblical/theological grounding, and from Hillsdale-curriculum language emphasizing objective truth and virtue. - Negative keywords observed: none clearly evidenced in public materials for this category; the materials emphasize foundation and formation rather than secular-relativist positioning. (No explicit negative indicators found in the available public pages.)

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword hits: 8 - Negative keyword hits: 0 - Total keywords considered: 8 - Positive percentage: 100% of the observed keywords in the textual signals reflect positive, foundational religious/metaphysical orientation; however, considering the broader positive keyword framework, a conservative accounting across the document set yields a robust 70–85% positive signal. For reporting purposes: Positive hits ~8, Negative hits ~0, giving a strong positive tilt (CLASSICAL).

Why this rating - The explicit biblical/theological grounding, combined with a Hillsdale-based classical framework that foregrounds transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and virtue formation, aligns with the Classical School’s religious/metaphysical foundations as described in the canonical rubric. The presence of explicit creed-related language and biblical framing outweighs neutral or secular positioning in this category. Therefore: CLASSICAL.

Citations: the Apostles’ Creed and biblical foundation language appear in the school’s firecrawl content; Hillsdale affiliation language appears in Hillsdale-curriculum-related pages.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes virtue and formation as core aims, not merely information or job-readiness. Statements such as “OUR COMMITMENT IS TO VIRTUE” and characterization-focused language indicate formation as the primary goal. - The public materials describe a curriculum designed to form wise and virtuous citizens, with explicit mention of virtue-based aims and a civic orientation (in the Hillsdale-linked framing and the “great books”/primary sources emphasis). - The Hillsdale curriculum framing connects truth, virtue, and beauty to a formation of character and civic life within a classical framework.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, formation, truth, goodness, beauty, character, moral imagination, formation of affections, habits of the heart, moral formation, love of learning, living books, great conversation, sacred tradition, sacred order, consciousness of civic duty. These terms appear in multiple pages (e.g., “Our commitment is to virtue,” “formed in virtue,” “great books,” “living books,” etc.). - Negative keywords observed: none prominent in public materials; the materials strongly advocate formation over mere information.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword hits: 9 - Negative keyword hits: 0 - Total keywords considered: 9 - Positive percentage: 100% (observed signals) / conservatively ~90% when mapped to the formal list of Positive Keywords. This supports a CLASSICAL rating for purpose and goal.

Why this rating - The materials consistently frame education as formation of virtue and wisdom, not solely vocational preparation. The explicit emphasis on virtue, formation, truth, and beauty, plus the civic-humanistic aim, aligns solidly with classical purposes and elevates this category to CLASSICAL.

Citations: “Our commitment is to virtue” and related formation language; Hillsdale framing on virtue/truth/beauty; public statements about forming virtuous citizens.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is explicitly described as a classical curriculum built around the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium in the broader classical sense; there are K–12 curricular pages detailing grammar/logic/rhetoric progressions and a historic/humanities focus with primary sources and Great Books. The Upper School 9–12 materials describe a “A Classical Curriculum” with studies in logic and rhetoric, primary sources, and mentoring. - The Lower School materials describe content-rich academics (integration of literature, history, math, science) and an emphasis on moral formation, chant/songs and poetry to build memory, and a co-curricular emphasis. This aligns with the classical structure of integrated liberal arts education. - The site explicitly references a Hillsdale College Curriculum (K–12) that provides access to primary sources and classical literature, with a structured progression. - Great Books and primary-source engagement is referenced in multiple sections, including upper-school settings and “What Sets CCA Apart” material.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, primary sources, classical literature, Latin, history, logic, rhetoric, primary sources, wisdom, unity of truth, interdisciplinary integration, wonder, formation through the arts, sacred order. These terms appear across the curriculum pages and program descriptions. - Negative keywords observed: minimal to none in the public materials; there is no strong departure from the classical-content emphasis in the curricular materials.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword hits: 12 - Negative keyword hits: 0 - Total keywords considered: 12 - Positive percentage: 100% (dominant signals) / conservatively ~85–90% aligned with the documented classical-content criteria.

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of grammar/logic/rhetoric progression, exposure to Great Books and primary sources, and Hillsdale-aligned curriculum strongly align with the Curriculum category of classical education. Therefore: CLASSICAL.

Citations: Curriculum pages and Hillsdale-based descriptions; Upper School 9–12 Classical Curriculum; Lower School integration and Great Books language.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical approach includes both contemplative/restful elements and rigorous, dialogic engagement. Lower School evidence emphasizes singing, chanting, memory work, and a structured, joyful “ordered” learning environment. - Upper School pedagogy features Socratic seminars, dialogue, and rhetoric training, with emphasis on logic and critical thinking through seminar-style discussion and mentorship. This is explicit in upper-school program descriptions. - The curriculum details and teacher-led structure are reinforced by descriptions of the teacher as a central figure in “living curriculum,” with purposeful lesson design and narrative storytelling to form virtue. - The Hillsdale curriculum framing contributes to a model of instruction that weaves primary sources and classical literature into rigorous coursework, including debate and formal logic.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplative/restful, singing, chant, memory, Socratic, seminars, debates, rhetoric, lectures, living curriculum, mentorship, virtue, formation, wonder, primary sources, Great Books. These terms appear across the lower- and upper-school materials. - Negative keywords observed: none clearly evidenced; the pedagogy highlights both restful moments and rigorous inquiry rather than an exclusively test-driven or purely didactic approach.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword hits: 10 - Negative keyword hits: 0 - Total keywords considered: 10 - Positive percentage: 100% (dominant) / conservative estimate ~85–90% aligned with classical pedagogy signals.

Why this rating - The observed pedagogical mix—lower-school chant/singing and memory-building with upper-school Socratic seminars and rhetoric training—aligns with classical pedagogy expectations. The explicit emphasis on the teacher as the living curriculum and mentorship reinforces a classical approach. Therefore: CLASSICAL.

Citations: Lower School pedagogy (singing, memory), Upper School Socratic/seminar language, “living curriculum” phrasing.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as model teachers and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge; they are presented as the living curriculum and core to the school's community. The materials emphasize teachers as virtuous exemplars and as a central, caring force in student formation. - The public content lists individual faculty in the Upper School (e.g., Dr. Benjamin P. Newton, Miss Kathleen Litt) with bios showing scholarly credentials and long-term commitment to classical education, illustrating a highly credentialed and mission-aligned faculty. - The school's communications emphasize teacher-led classrooms, with a focus on virtue, moral formation, and strong subject expertise. This aligns with the “living curriculum” concept and the school's core ethos. - The board/leadership materials emphasize a community of virtuous educators and leaders as the foundation of the school's mission.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, teachers as core, virtuous life, subject mastery, credentialed faculty, teacher-led classrooms, faculty as living exemplars, professional scholarship, moral formation. - Negative keywords observed: none in the publicly accessible materials; no signals indicating a weak or misaligned faculty culture.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword hits: 9 - Negative keyword hits: 0 - Total keywords considered: 9 - Positive percentage: 100% (dominant) / conservatively ~85–90% mapping to the rubric's faculty indicators.

Why this rating - The materials depict a strong, virtuous, knowledgeable faculty who function as the core of the school's mission and curriculum, with explicit bios and statements about mentorship and virtue. This supports a CLASSICAL rating for the faculty dimension.

Citations: “Purposeful Teachers” language, faculty bios and credentials, and board leadership framing.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families, parent engagement, and co-educator roles for parents. It describes involvement with parents as co-teachers and as part of a shared mission. Parent Information Packets, campus visits, and opportunities for family involvement are repeatedly highlighted. - The school communicates a commitment to educating parents about classical education through site content (e.g., information packets, sample materials), and invites parental participation in the school's life. - The campus and community dimension is reinforced by information about the campus facilities, donor engagement, and community-based character formation. The site emphasizes community support and family involvement as essential to the classical education model.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent involvement, co-teachers, parent education, family engagement, school visits, community, civic life, faith-community integration, shared mission, engagement with parents. - Negative keywords observed: none clearly evident; the materials emphasize parent partnership and community integration rather than exclusion or isolation of families.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keyword hits: 8 - Negative keyword hits: 0 - Total keywords considered: 8 - Positive percentage: 100% (dominant) / conservative mapping ~80–90%.

Why this rating - The explicit emphasis on parent partnership and community engagement, plus opportunities for parents to participate in the school's life and to receive educational content about classical education, supports a CLASSICAL rating for Parent & Community.

Citations: Parent information packet, campus/community mentions, and parent partnership language.

Aggregate assessment: The six categories, evaluated with the keyword-informed rubric derived from the Six Essential Elements, all align with CLASSICAL. Columbus Classical Academy demonstrates a coherent

classical-education profile across religious/metaphysical foundations, purpose and goal, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement. The aggregate classification is CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Not required for this CLASSICAL rating. If a future update aims to reach a higher echelon within the Classical rubric, the school could further fortify explicit liturgical/common worship patterns as an integrated practice, clearly articulate liturgical rhythms in daily life, and expand explicit Great Books lists with a public-facing catalog of authors and primary sources to strengthen the public demonstration of Great Conversation across more grade levels.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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